Q. Many critics have found this an immensely readable but complicated book. What moved you to write it?

A. There were several things I was trying to do...I had not read a book in English about India in which I felt that I could recognise the place that I grew up in. So I started out really trying to write a book which would describe what it felt like growing up in Bombay...a kind of Indian 'big city novel'... The other impulse came from a feeling that by the end of the Emergency a period of Indian history had ended, that the bit between independence and 1977 represented a phase in the history of the country which was different from what preceded it. Then one of the things which the book is centrally about is the way in which public affairs and private lives intermingle and penetrate each other...

Q. Are you trying to reach out to western readers exclusively or do you assume that there will be many Indian and Pakistani readers as well. How much do you feel you have to explain?


Books

An Indian Scheherazade

SALMAN RUSHDIE
"A Big City Novel"

FROM THE ARCHIVES
May 16, 1981

Interview
"A Big City Novel"

A. I didn't conceive of an ideal reader except perhaps myself...For most of the time I wasn't sure that the book would be published so I was just writing in a bloody-minded attitude the way I wanted to write it. I think the book will have a larger western audience. But I hoped that Indian and Pakistani readers would not find it forced or untrue and I explained only as much as I thought necessary for the action of the book.

–Salman Rushdie talked to Bonny Mukherjee

TURNING A PAGE

- **Created an international market for Indian English writing**
- **Some Indian English writers were soon able to command hefty advances**
- **Gave Indian writing in English a strong identity**
- **The Jaipur Literature Festival, said to be one of the world's largest, launched in 2006 to great success on the back of a mature literary culture in India**
- **In 2022, Geetanjali Shree's *Tomb of Sand*, translated from Hindi into English, won the International Booker Prize, bringing vernacular Indian fiction into the international spotlight**

$1

Amount for which Salman Rushdie sold the rights for the film version of *Midnight's Children*. It was directed by Deepa Mehta, released in 2012

DID YOU KNOW?

Indira Gandhi took offence to a sentence in *Midnight's Children*, about her son Sanjay Gandhi in Chapter 28. Rushdie agreed to remove it after Mrs G filed a case in the British courts

The writers who emerged in Rushdie's wake charted their own, very individual, paths. Of course, they all belonged to the cosy club of India's anglophone elites. To list some prominent examples: *The Golden Gate* (1986) by Vikram Seth; *The Circle of Reason* (1986) by Amitav Ghosh; *English, August* (1988) by Upamanyu Chatterjee; *The Great Indian Novel* (1989) by Shashi Tharoor; *Such a Long Journey* (1991) by Rohinton Mistry; *The God of Small Things* (1997) by Arundhati Roy. Many of these were international bestsellers that launched a publishing revolution and the writing ambitions of countless other Indians all over the world.

Indian scholar and professor Rajeswari Sunder Rajan writes: "*Midnight's Children* and its successor novels over the next quarter-century ostentatiously bore the burden of nation." Even while delineating the notion of nationhood, these novels were intensely personal and fleshed out relatable characters. By the time Arundhati Roy received a half-million pound advance for *The God of Small Things*, Indian English fiction had well and truly arrived.

Rushdie himself had a successful if turbulent trajectory, after a fatwa was issued for perceived blasphemy in *The Satanic Verses* (1988), forcing him into hiding for a decade. In April this year, he responded to the stabbing attack on him in 2022 in the only way a writer can, by publishing the autobiographical *Knife: Meditations After an Attempted Murder*. Expectedly, it was a bestseller. ■